

Chicken and Okra Gumbo

A slow Southern gumbo built around a 30-minute dark roux and fresh okra from the backyard raised beds. This is the most technically demanding recipe in the Jake's Table Southern Comfort track - and the most rewarding. The roux alone requires 25-35 minutes of uninterrupted stirring. Students who make it through the roux feel a genuine sense of accomplishment, and the depth of flavor it produces is unlike anything achievable through shortcuts.

Ingredients (serves 8)

The Roux

- ½ cup neutral oil (vegetable or canola - not olive)
- ½ cup all-purpose flour

The Trinity and Aromatics

- 1 large yellow onion, diced fine
- 4 stalks celery, diced fine
- 1 large green bell pepper, diced fine
- 6 cloves garlic, minced
- 2 bay leaves
- 1 tsp dried thyme
- ½ tsp dried oregano

Proteins

- 2 lb bone-in chicken thighs (skin on)
- 1 lb andouille sausage, sliced
- ½ lb medium shrimp, peeled and deveined (added last)

Gumbo Body

- 1½ lb fresh okra, sliced ½ inch (from backyard beds or Buford Highway Farmers Market)
- 8 cups rich chicken stock (homemade preferred)
- 1 can (14 oz) diced tomatoes, drained
- Salt, black pepper, cayenne to taste
- Filé powder - 1 tsp, stirred in off heat at serving

Service

- Long-grain white rice, cooked separately
 - Sliced scallions and flat-leaf parsley for garnish
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The Roux - A Dedicated Section

The dark roux is the soul of this gumbo. It takes 25-35 minutes and requires constant attention. The goal is a roux the color of dark chocolate - not milk chocolate, not coffee. Dark chocolate. At this color, the roux has developed the complex, toasty, almost nutty flavor that defines a proper Cajun-Creole

gumbo. A shortcut roux is immediately identifiable by the absence of that depth.

Method: Heat oil in a heavy Dutch oven over medium to medium-high heat. Add flour all at once. Stir immediately and constantly with a wooden spoon or flat-bottomed whisk. Never stop stirring. Never walk away. Never increase the heat to rush it - a burnt roux is irreversible and will make the entire pot bitter.

The roux will progress through these stages: pale yellow (2-5 min), peanut butter (8-12 min), milk chocolate (15-20 min), and finally dark chocolate (25-35 min). Each stage smells different - the early stages smell raw, then nutty, then rich and complex. If the roux smells burnt or begins to smoke, reduce heat immediately.

Safety: Dark roux reaches temperatures above 300°F. Treat it like hot oil - keep children away from the stove, use a long spoon, and if it splashes, it burns. The French Creole term for roux is 'Cajun napalm.' This is not an exaggeration.

Method

1. **Brown the chicken and andouille.** Season chicken thighs generously with salt, pepper, and a little cayenne. Brown skin-side down in a separate pan over high heat for 4-5 minutes. Remove. Brown andouille slices. Set both aside. Reserve any accumulated chicken drippings to add to the gumbo stock later.
2. **Make the dark roux** as described above. When the roux reaches dark chocolate color, immediately add the trinity (onion, celery, bell pepper). The vegetables will sizzle and steam dramatically, dropping the temperature of the roux. Stir constantly. The vegetables will absorb the roux and soften over about 5 minutes.
3. **Add garlic and herbs.** Stir in garlic, thyme, oregano, and bay leaves. Cook 2 minutes.
4. **Add stock gradually.** Ladle in the warm stock one cup at a time, stirring thoroughly between each addition to prevent lumps. Once all the stock is incorporated and smooth, the gumbo base is established.
5. **Add the proteins.** Nestle the browned chicken thighs and andouille into the pot. Add the drained tomatoes. Bring to a low simmer.
6. **Simmer 45 minutes.** Cook uncovered at a gentle simmer, stirring occasionally. The chicken will become fall-off-the-bone tender. Skim any fat that rises to the surface.
7. **Remove chicken and shred.** Pull the chicken thighs out. Discard skin and bones. Shred the meat and return it to the pot.
8. **Add the okra.** Stir in the sliced fresh okra. Simmer 15-20 minutes until the okra is tender and its natural thickening (mucilage) has integrated into the gumbo. Do not overcook - okra should be tender but not disintegrated.
9. **Add shrimp.** In the last 5 minutes of cooking, stir in the shrimp. Cook until just pink, about 4-5 minutes.
10. **Season and finish.** Taste carefully and adjust salt, pepper, and cayenne. Remove from heat and stir in filé powder. Do not boil after adding filé - it will turn stringy.

11. **Serve over rice.** Ladle into wide bowls over a mound of white rice. Garnish with scallions and parsley. Serve hot.

Sourcing and Garden Notes

Fresh okra is available from the backyard raised beds from July through September in Atlanta. Jake plants two okra rows in the hottest garden bed each year - okra thrives in Georgia heat and produces prolifically from midsummer through first frost. For class sessions outside the garden season, Buford Highway Farmers Market carries fresh okra from Georgia and Alabama growers nearly year-round.

Variations

Seafood-only gumbo: Omit chicken and andouille. Use 1 lb shrimp, 1 lb crab claws, and ½ lb oysters. Proceed with the same roux and base. Adjust cooking time - all seafood goes in during the final 8 minutes.

Andouille addition: For a smokier, meatier gumbo, double the andouille and omit the shrimp. This version is better for large groups (easier logistics) and reheats exceptionally well.